Hurst slipped out of bed, anxious. Today was the day he would be Called. His feet hit the dirt floor, and he slipped into the main hall. He saw the spirits swirling all around the house. Fire, warmth, food, joy, love. Someone was cooking breakfast for the household. He saw House-Mother and Gathering-Father sitting in the kitchen, stirring the large pot. Several older children milled about, each preparing for their Calling.

Hurst hoped he would have the same Calling as Sight-Mother. Hurst didn't dislike Spirit-Father, but he was scared of the deep waters where Spirit-Father fished. He still remembered the water spirit that tried to drown him. Hurst shuddered. He looked around the room, seeing the fresh Terra Gourds for the stew. "If they're here, that means….". He thought correctly. Sight-Mother standing by the doorway outside, staring at him. He saw the look in her eyes and sighed. That was the look of someone who wasn't about to let her son hide from his duties.

He scampered over to her, waiting to hear what his new task would be. Sight-Mother saw the look in his eyes and snorted. "Are you really that scared of being Called to the same task as Spirit-Father?" Hurst nodded, looking at the floor. It was shameful to admit such a thing, but it was true. Sight-Mother sighed, crouching down to eye level with Hurst. She put a hand on Hurst's shoulder. "I know the waters scare you, but you have the spirits about you! They love you even more than Spirit-Father! Even more than Fisher Morgan!".

"I know Sight-Mother. I'm just…scared. What if it comes back? What if it finds me again? What if…Spirit-Father isn't there to save me this time?" Hurst felt panic surging in his chest. He barely managed to get the last sentence out from his mouth before his teeth chattered too much to continue.

Sight-Mother smiled and hugged Hurst. He hugged her back. Her warm embrace caused his panic and fear to melt away, and all he felt was her warmth. She pulled away and pursed her lips. She seemed to consider something, then spoke. "If you swear on the gods to return before High Sun and take someone with you, I'll permit you to explore the near forests before the Calling Ceremony." Hurst's eyes widened. Sight-Mother never let him wander the forests. She spoke of the trickster gods and evil demons that lived within.

"Can I take Sylva?" Sight-Mother smiled like she expected this question. She nodded causing Hurst to jump up and kiss her on the cheek. "I promise to return by High Sun! I love you Sight-Mother!" Hurst didn't see her reaction; he was already running to Sylva's household. He saw Sylva's Spirit-Mother and Sight-Father sitting in the grass around their household. He ran up and told her what Sight-Mother said. Sylva's Spirit-Mother nodded, calling for Sylva.

Hurst could barely contain his excitement when he saw a flash of green hair in the window of Sylva's household. He watched as she climbed up the broken wall and ran over to him. Her long green hair was styled into a braid. Sylva's Sight-Father reminded them to be back by High Sun.

They were to join the rest of the eight-year-olds for the Calling Ceremony. Hurst and Sylva nodded and ran off into the woods.

Hurst and Sylva wandered the forest for about an hour before finding some ancient ruins. Sylva always found them fascinating, so she dragged Hurst towards them. As he was looking at a strange colored glass section, he heard Sylva's voice behind him. "What do you think they'll Call you to be?"

Hurst turned around and saw Sylva sitting on a ruined bench, her legs too short for her feet to reach the ground. He thought for a moment then responded. "I think they'll call me to be a Fisher." Sylva grimaced. She knew how much Hurst hated the rickety boats and deep water of the Fishers.

Sylva laid down on the bench, staring up at the sky. She took a deep breath and then spoke. "When I get Called as Apprentice Prophet, I get to choose one Apostle. If you want, I'll pick you." Hurst felt his brain stop. He turned to Sylva, feeling hopeful for the first time in nearly a week.

"Really?" Sylva nodded. Hurst ran over to her and leapt onto the bench. She sat up, startled, right as Hurst pulled her into an embrace. "Thank you. You're my best friend!" Sylva laughed and pushed Hurst away.

"Even after I'm Apprentice Prophet, you can't tell anyone I told you about my gift. It's supposed to be a secret only the Prophet and Watcher know." Sylva looked Hurst dead in the eye when she spoke. "No matter what, you have to keep it secret." Hurst nodded his head quickly. He only knew of Sylva's gift because on one of their adventures, he saw her talking to the spirits. He knew it was supposed to be a secret. He also knew Sylva was being overly cautious, as everyone would know of her gift after today, and most the adults would know she had told Hurst.

"I promise. I won't tell anyone." Sylva let out a breath, clearly relieved. Hurst looked around, realizing it was getting close to High Sun. "We need to head back!" He hopped off the bench, holding his hand out for Sylva to climb down. She took his hand and slid off the bench, landing next to him on the ground.

They started to head back to Mistgrove. Hurst noticed Sylva seemed worried about something, but when he asked her, she shook her head. She said the spirits were saying something strange, but it wasn't anything that they needed to concern themselves with. Hurst shrugged and kept leading the way home. After a few minutes, he was pretty sure they were close to Mistgrove. As he stopped to tell Sylva, he heard a scream behind him. He spun around and saw Sylva was no longer following him. He heard another scream, and he ran towards it.

He burst into a small clearing, seeing Sylva on the ground, facing towards a creature he didn't recognize. Sylva was scrambling away from the creature in front of her. Hurst looked at the creature crawling towards her. It had 6 legs, 3 on each side. It had 4 eyes, each a different

color. It opened its massive mouth, dark orange tongue slipping out, split at the ends like a snake. Hurst leapt towards Sylva, standing in between the creature and Sylva.

Sylva was barely coherent. She was screaming about the voice of the demon. It was unlike anything she had ever heard. It dripped with malice. Hurst looked back at her, and saw that she curled up into a ball, pressing her hands to her ears. He turned back to the demon and stared it dead in the eye.

Spirit-Father told me the demons get stronger if they know you're afraid of them. That's why the water demon nearly drowned me. I can't let it know I'm afraid. Hurst started shouting at the demon. "You do not scare me! I am Hurst of Mistgrove! You have no claim to us! You have no claim to ME!".

A voice unlike anything Hurst had ever heard spoke. It felt like it was formed of pure malice. He felt his blood freeze, and his very soul seemed to quiver. "I have claim to all. Two mere Voices have no power over me.". The demon paused and seemed to laugh. "Even calling you Voices is absurd. The girl is barely a Squeak, and you are but a Whisper". Hurst felt his fear overwhelm him. He wanted to turn and run. He knew if he didn't the demon would devour him. But Sylva was behind him. He refused to leave her.

Hurst spoke quickly. "Sylva, I have a plan. I'm going to try to draw this thing away from you. Run to Mistgrove. Find the Watcher. Tell her about this." Sylva stared at Hurst, eyes completely unfocused. Her fear was overwhelming her. Hurst clapped his hands together in front of her, and she focused on him. "You hear me? GO!" Sylva shook her head. She was shaking. She was too scared to even stand up. Hurst turned back to the demon. He felt his fear trying to force him to fall, but he refused. He kept standing. The demon tilted its head and then spun around. Hurst could've sworn he saw a small gray pomegranate in the direction the demon faced, but it was gone before he could process it. Behind where he saw the Pomegranate, he saw a figure standing there.

"Now little beastie, let's leave the kids alone, eh?" The words were jovial, but cold as ice. "We don't wanna pluck the little buds before they even have a chance to sprout, do we?" The demon leapt away from the figure, growling.

"You… What power is that? What manner of creature are you?" The demon seemed to be the prey, not the predator. "How can you withstand our voice?"

The figure in the forest walked out, revealing them to be a tall woman with dark brown hair. She had several scars on her face, with dark purple eyes. She had a slight smirk on her face, but her eyes were hard as steel. "Me? They call me Watcher. You? You can call me ya doom". The demon crouched down, fear emanating from it. "Now, ya can leave the kiddos alone, or we can have a little fight." The demon seemed to consider this, then bolted into the shadow. The Watcher sighed, turning to Hurst and Sylva.

“Sylva, is that you there?” Sylva slipped her hands off her ears and looked up at the Watcher. The Watcher smiled, turning to Hurst. “Thank ya for keepin’ an eye on Sylva. We can’t afford to lose her to a little beastie like that!” Hurst nodded, still feeling the effects of the demon’s voice on him. The Watcher squinted, then crouched down to stare at him. “Boy, can ya hear the spirits too?” Hurst shook his head. He’d never been able to hear the spirits as long as he could remember.

The Watcher looked over at Sylva, and Sylva nodded. The Watcher looked back at Hurst and pondered for a moment. “The demons voice really did ya two in, didn’t it?” Hurst and Sylva nodded. The Watcher laughed. “Well, there’s a positive. We got another Speaker!”. Hurst and Sylva stared at each other, confused. The Watcher stood up and helped the kids up. “If ya can hear the demon, ya can hear the spirits. The gift sometimes takes a bit to start up!” Hurst looked up at the Watcher, surprised.

“I can hear the spirits?” Hurst didn’t process it at first. Hearing the spirits meant he could only be Called as the Prophet or the Watcher.

“Sure! Try an listen for a second!” Hurst paused, listening to the forest around him. He started to hear faint but distinct voices around him. He jumped up, causing The Watcher to start laughing. “See! Ya have the gift!”

Hurst thought for a moment. He wasn’t going to be a Fisher. He wasn’t going to be a Fisher. The Watcher placed a hand on his shoulder, and he turned around to see she was on one knee, staring him in the eye. “What ya did was brave, but dangerous.” She grabbed Hurst’s other shoulder, making sure he looked her in the eyes. “I respect ya bravery. In fact, I have an offer for ya. Do ya wanna be my Apprentice?”

Hurst didn’t hesitate. “Yes!”. The Watcher smiled and stood up. She scooped up Sylva in her arms and started walking them back to Mistgrove. They didn’t say much on the walk back. When they reached the edge of the town, Sylva spoke up.

“Hurst?”

“Yeah Sylva?”

“Thank you.”

Hurst smiled. “Of course! It’s just early practice for when I’m Watcher! I’ll have to keep everyone safe!”

Sylva laughed. “I believe in you. You’ll keep everyone safe! We’ll never have to worry once Watcher Hurst is here!”

Hurst felt Ward bump into his leg. He sat up and looked at them. It was a dream of his past. One he hadn't had for years. "We're getting close to Mistgrove. Are you sure about this?" Ward seemed to feel guilty about pushing Hurst to return.

"I'm sure Ward. The boat ride has been rough, but I needed to return at least once." Hurst tapped the small bag on the floor by his hammock. "I have the final offering for my friends. After that, it's finally over."

Ward rolled onto the floor and bounced up and down. They seemed nervous but spoke. "Are you going to speak with Sylva?"

Hurst paused and looked down at Ward. "If she wishes to meet me at their graves, I shall. Otherwise, she and I have nothing to say to one another. I broke my promise. She failed her duties. We are both equally guilty."

Ward deflated a bit but seemed to accept this. Hurst stood up and walked out of his cabin. He walked onto the deck and saw the deep mists around his homeland. He called the captain and pointed to the beach next to them. "Here will do. Thank you."

"Yer sure? That there leads to just forest."

"I am certain. Thank you again for the passage. I have left the payment on the hammock." Hurst and Ward hopped off the boat and started walking towards Mistgrove. Ward rolled alongside Hurst, preparing for Hurst's final ever visit to Mistgrove.